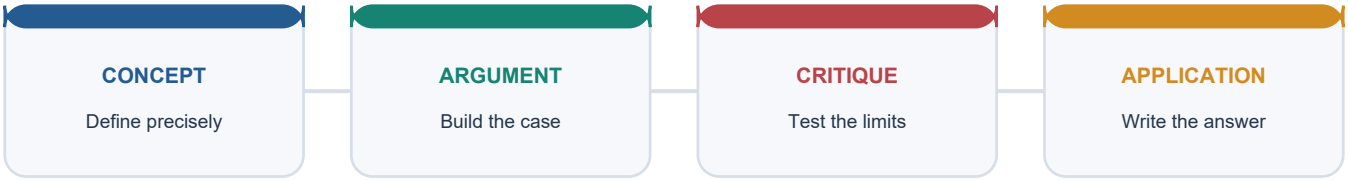
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Ghaznavids & the Ghurian Invasions - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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The Ghaznavids & the Ghurian Invasions - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 01

Which background most plausibly explains why Ghazni could become the seat of a new frontier power in the tenth century?

- A. Samanid use of Turkic military commanders allowed a frontier office at Ghazni to turn into dynastic power.
- B. Ghazni had already been the capital of the Delhi Sultanate.
- C. Ghazni emerged only after Muizz al-Din's victory at Tarain II.
- D. Ghazni rose because the Cholas sought an Afghan alliance.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. The Ghaznavid rise grew out of the Samanid frontier world in which military commanders such as Alp-tigin could convert office into rule.
- B. Incorrect. Delhi became a conquest-centre only in the later Ghurid-Sultanate sequence, not in tenth-century Ghazni.
- C. Incorrect. Tarain II belongs to 1192, whereas Ghazni had been a power centre since Alp-tigin and Sabuktigin long before that.
- D. Incorrect. South Indian Chola politics had no role in creating the Ghazni frontier state described in this topic.

Trap: reading Ghazni backward through Sultanate history instead of placing it in the Samanid-Afghan frontier setting.

Workbook MCQ 02

Which statement best captures Sabuktigin's place in Topic 02?

- A. He annexed the whole Ganga valley after 1018.
- B. He consolidated Ghazni and fought Jayapala before Mahmud expanded the state.
- C. He wrote Kitab al-Hind to justify the Somnath raid.
- D. He was the Ghurid commander defeated in Gujarat in 1178.

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. The 1018 Ganga-valley raid was Mahmud's and did not create a whole-valley annexation in any case.
- B. Correct. Sabuktigin stands between Alp-tigin and Mahmud as the ruler who stabilised Ghazni and pushed the Shahi frontier struggle forward.
- C. Incorrect. Kitab al-Hind is associated with al-Biruni, not with Sabuktigin.
- D. Incorrect. The Gujarat defeat of 1178 belongs to Muizz al-Din's Ghurid phase, almost two centuries later.

Trap: collapsing Sabuktigin into either Mahmud's later raids or Muizz al-Din's much later Ghurid campaigns.

Workbook MCQ 03

Consider the following sequence of events: 1. Somnath raid 2. Defeat of Jayapala near Peshawar 3. Mathura-Kanauj raid 4. Defeat of Anandapala and overrun of Nandana. Which is the correct chronological order?

- A. 2-3-4-1
- B. 4-2-3-1
- C. 2-4-3-1
- D. 3-2-4-1

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. This places the 1018 raid before the Anandapala-Nandana frontier phase, which reverses the sequence.
- B. Incorrect. Anandapala's defeat came after Jayapala's, not before it.
- C. Correct. The secure order is 1001, c.1008-09, 1018, then 1025.
- D. Incorrect. The Mathura-Kanauj raid followed the early Shahi wars rather than preceding them.

Trap: memorising famous raids while losing the frontier-war chronology that made them possible.

Workbook MCQ 04

Which campaign-outcome pairing is correctly matched?

- A. 1018 Mathura-Kanauj raid - permanent Ghaznavid province in the middle Ganga valley
- B. 1025 Somnath raid - durable annexation of Gujarat
- C. 1191 Tarain I - extinction of Chahamana military capacity
- D. 1194 Chandawar - defeat of Jaichandra and opening toward the upper Ganga region

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. The 1018 operation produced plunder and shock, not a lasting middle-Ganga province.
- B. Incorrect. Mahmud returned after Somnath and did not hold Gujarat as a durable Ghaznavid possession.
- C. Incorrect. Tarain I was a Ghurid defeat, so it cannot stand for Chahamana extinction.
- D. Correct. Chandawar broke Jaichandra's power and widened Ghurid access into the upper Ganga zone.

Trap: equating every spectacular victory or raid with immediate territorial incorporation.

Workbook MCQ 05

How should the textbook statement that Mahmud made "seventeen" Indian expeditions be used in an exam answer?

- A. As a conventional count that signals repeated campaigning, while noting that the counting of separate operations is not perfectly uniform.
- B. As proof that every expedition is equally documented with exact figures.
- C. As evidence that all campaigns occurred after Somnath.
- D. As an official Delhi Sultanate administrative classification.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. The number is best handled as a textbook shorthand for frequency, not as a fully audited spreadsheet of identical operations.
- B. Incorrect. Chronicle traditions do not verify every campaign with the same precision or numerical reliability.
- C. Incorrect. Somnath came late in Mahmud's career, not before all the other expeditions.
- D. Incorrect. The phrase describes Mahmud's raids, not a later Sultanate bureaucratic category.

Trap: treating a conventional campaign count as if it were an uncontested administrative dataset.

Workbook MCQ 06

Which set contains only territories that became Mahmud's more durable Indian gains rather than deep-plains raid targets?

- A. Mathura, Kanauj and Somnath
- B. Punjab and Multan
- C. Gujarat and Bengal
- D. Ajmer and Delhi

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. These were famous raid targets, but Mahmud did not turn them into stable inland provinces.
- B. Correct. Punjab and Multan formed the durable frontier base that outlasted the one-strike raids.

- C. Incorrect. Gujarat was raided and Bengal was not a Ghaznavid gain under Mahmud.
- D. Incorrect. Ajmer and Delhi enter the story through later Ghurid advances, not Mahmud's durable acquisitions.

Trap: mistaking the most famous raid destinations for the areas of longest Ghaznavid control.

Workbook MCQ 07

A historian emphasises roads, forts, remounts and intelligence between Ghazni and the Kabul-Jalalabad-Punjab zone. What is the best inference?

- A. Mountain geography by itself mechanically guaranteed victory.
- B. Religious zeal mattered more than all material factors combined.
- C. Frontier conquest became sustainable only when geography was turned into usable infrastructure.
- D. Once roads existed, interior Indian politics ceased to matter.

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Terrain offered possibilities, but it had to be organised through roads, forts and supply systems.
- B. Incorrect. The point of this evidence is logistical capacity, not the cancellation of every other motive.
- C. Correct. The frontier became strategically usable when routes and bases converted physical space into repeatable campaigning capacity.
- D. Incorrect. Infrastructure improved access, yet local coalitions, forts and rival dynasties still shaped outcomes.

Trap: turning logistical explanation either into geographical determinism or into the denial of political contingency.

Workbook MCQ 08

Which statement about the 1025 Somnath raid is most defensible?

- A. It can be reconstructed from one uncontested contemporary eyewitness record.
- B. It proves that all temple attacks in medieval India had identical motives.
- C. It ended with the immediate installation of a Ghaznavid governor at Anhilwara.
- D. It joined wealth, prestige and religious-political symbolism, but its later memory far exceeds any simple one-source narrative.

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. Somnath must be pieced together from layered evidence rather than a single transparent eyewitness chronicle.
- B. Incorrect. Temple warfare had overlapping but not identical political, fiscal and symbolic contexts across cases.
- C. Incorrect. Mahmud returned after the raid, so Gujarat was not secured as a regular Ghaznavid province.
- D. Correct. This option preserves both the event's violence and the need to separate 1025 from later ideological memory.

Trap: letting the fame of Somnath erase the difference between a raid, its source layers and its later political afterlife.

Workbook MCQ 09

Which evidentiary practice is safest when using later Persian narratives about Somnath?

- A. Separate early evidence, later amplification, local traditions and modern political memory before making claims.
- B. Assume every later dramatic speech or loot total is audited fact because it appears in Persian prose.
- C. Treat one silence in a donor inscription as proof that nothing disruptive occurred.
- D. Read Prithviraj Raso as the earliest and most direct Somnath report.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Source criticism begins by sorting chronology, genre and memory layers before drawing conclusions.
- B. Incorrect. Literary elaboration and panegyric style prevent later Persian prose from functioning as automatic numerical proof.

- C. Incorrect. Silence in a donor or genealogical record cannot by itself settle the scale or meaning of a violent event.
- D. Incorrect. Prithviraj Raso is a later heroic tradition unrelated to being the earliest Somnath testimony.

Trap: promoting a later narrative flourish into primary evidence without first checking date, genre and borrowing.

Workbook MCQ 10

Which limitation most clearly qualifies al-Biruni as a source?

- A. He never engaged with Sanskrit learning.
- B. His social observations are sharpened by learning yet narrowed by elite textual access and a north-western vantage.
- C. He wrote only a battle chronicle for Mahmud's court.
- D. He described only South Indian temple networks.

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. Al-Biruni is valuable precisely because he did engage deeply with Sanskrit knowledge traditions.
- B. Correct. His comparative brilliance coexists with limits of interlocutor base, regional location and social reach.
- C. Incorrect. Kitab al-Hind is a comparative scholarly work, not merely a campaign chronicle.
- D. Incorrect. His interests ranged across religion, science, calendars and social categories, not only southern temples.

Trap: swinging from uncritical praise of al-Biruni to total trust in his representativeness for all of India.

Workbook MCQ 11

Which source-description pair is correctly matched?

- A. Bayhaqi - later Rajput heroic romance about Tarain
- B. Hasan Nizami - Ghaznavid eyewitness account ending before Somnath
- C. Minhaj-us-Siraj - thirteenth-century dynastic history preserving Ghurid genealogy and early Sultanate sequence
- D. Prithviraj Raso - contemporary administrative register of Delhi

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Bayhaqi is a Persian chancery insider tied mainly to Ghaznavid administrative and court politics, not Rajput romance.
- B. Incorrect. Hasan Nizami belongs to the early Indo-Persian conquest milieu, not the earlier Ghaznavid phase ending before Somnath.
- C. Correct. Minhaj's Tabaqat-i Nasiri is crucial for Ghurid lineage, commanders and early Sultanate sequencing.
- D. Incorrect. Prithviraj Raso is a layered later epic tradition rather than a contemporaneous Delhi register.

Trap: memorising famous book names without fixing their dynasty, date and genre.

Workbook MCQ 12

How should Firishta be used in this topic?

- A. As a direct contemporary auditor of Mahmud's eleventh-century army figures
- B. As the best evidence that al-Utbi personally saw Somnath
- C. As proof that all Rajput legends are historically exact
- D. As a much later compilational witness whose narratives need checking against earlier texts and material evidence

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. Firishta wrote centuries later and cannot function as a contemporary eleventh-century observer.
- B. Incorrect. A later compiler cannot retroactively prove what al-Utbi did or did not witness.
- C. Incorrect. Later compilations preserve memory and tradition, not blanket authentication of all legends.

- D. Correct. Firishta is useful for later historiographical transmission, but only with careful corroboration.

Trap: mistaking a readable late synthesis for direct access to eleventh- or twelfth-century facts.

Workbook MCQ 13

Which piece of evidence most directly weakens a religion-alone explanation of Mahmud's Indian campaigns?

- A. Ghaznavid armies could include Hindu officers or Jat soldiers even while court rhetoric used ghazi language.
- B. The Cholas controlled the Khyber Pass.
- C. al-Biruni served as Prithviraj's general.
- D. Somnath became a Mughal mint town immediately after 1025.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Mixed service personnel show that political and military practice was more complex than a simple civilisational bloc model.
- B. Incorrect. The Cholas were not the frontier power determining Mahmud's north-western campaigns.
- C. Incorrect. Al-Biruni was a scholar in the Ghaznavid world, not a Chahamana military commander.
- D. Incorrect. The option invents a later Mughal institutional outcome unrelated to Mahmud's raid.

Trap: confusing the presence of religious rhetoric with proof that every institutional choice followed a single motive.

Workbook MCQ 14

Match the event with the description: 1. 1001 2. c.1008-09 3. 1015 4. 1025; a. campaign frustrated by Kashmir terrain and weather b. Jayapala defeated near Peshawar/Waihind c. Somnath raid d. Anandapala defeated; Salt Range/Nandana overrun. Which option is correct?

- A. 1-a, 2-b, 3-d, 4-c
- B. 1-b, 2-d, 3-a, 4-c
- C. 1-d, 2-a, 3-b, 4-c
- D. 1-b, 2-a, 3-c, 4-d

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. This wrongly gives the Kashmir setback to 1001 and shifts Jayapala out of place.
- B. Correct. Jayapala belongs to 1001, Anandapala/Nandana to c.1008-09, the Kashmir frustration to 1015, and Somnath to 1025.
- C. Incorrect. It moves Anandapala ahead of Jayapala and scrambles the frontier chronology.
- D. Incorrect. It turns the 1015 Kashmir attempt into the Somnath raid, which distorts both theatre and date.

Trap: remembering isolated dates while losing the campaign map that links each date to a different theatre.

Workbook MCQ 15

Which statement best captures the textbook's treatment of Rajput resistance?

- A. Rajput polities offered no serious frontier resistance before 1192.
- B. Rajput defeat is explained sufficiently by a lack of personal bravery.
- C. Resistance was real and sometimes successful, but supra-regional coordination and strategic follow-through were uneven.
- D. The Shahis, Chauhans and Gahadavalas always fought as a permanent united command.

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. The Shahis, Tarain I and multiple regional battles show genuine resistance.
- B. Incorrect. Satish Chandra rejects moralistic reduction to courage and instead analyses organisation and strategy.
- C. Correct. This wording retains both Indian military capacity and the limits of wider coordination.
- D. Incorrect. Alliances could form, but there was no permanent all-India unified command structure.

Trap: forcing the evidence into either total collapse or perfect unity, instead of a graded picture of capacity and limits.

Workbook MCQ 16

Which statement about the fall of the Hindu Shahis is correct?

- A. It occurred in a single battle and ended all frontier resistance at once.
- B. It followed immediately after Tarain II.
- C. It was caused by Bengal's naval decline.
- D. It was a prolonged frontier struggle in which defeats of Jayapala and Anandapala were major steps rather than the whole story.

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. The Shahi collapse was cumulative and stretched across multiple campaigns and leaders.
- B. Incorrect. Tarain II belongs to the later Ghurid phase, long after the Shahi wars.
- C. Incorrect. Bengal's maritime history does not explain the Afghan-Punjab frontier contest.
- D. Correct. The Shahis fell through a sustained process of war, territorial loss and repeated pressure.

Trap: compressing a long frontier attrition story into one dramatic battle label.

Workbook MCQ 17

Which use of Kitab al-Hind is methodologically strongest?

- A. Using it comparatively for religion, science and social categories while still flagging its elite, textual and regional limits.
- B. Treating it as a neutral census of all Indian communities.
- C. Using it as a later Sufi malfuz collection.
- D. Ignoring its conceptual vocabulary because it offers only military numbers.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. This captures both the text's analytical value and the cautions needed for representativeness.
- B. Incorrect. Al-Biruni did not produce an all-India enumerative census in the modern sense.
- C. Incorrect. Kitab al-Hind is neither a Sufi conversation record nor a devotional compilation.
- D. Incorrect. The work is concept-rich and not reducible to campaign statistics.

Trap: using an analytical text either as a flawless survey or as if it were a completely different genre.

Workbook MCQ 18

Why did the Ghurid move into north India intensify after the western-centred option narrowed?

- A. Because the Delhi Sultanate invited Muizz al-Din eastward.
- B. Rivalry with Ghaznavids, pressure in the west and the opening through Punjab made India the more viable field of expansion.
- C. Because Ghur already ruled Kannauj through matrimonial alliance.
- D. Because the Chahamanas occupied Ghazni on the Ghurids' behalf.

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. The Delhi Sultanate did not yet exist to issue such an invitation.
- B. Correct. Strategic pressure and opportunity shifted Ghurid attention eastward toward Punjab and the Gangetic plain.
- C. Incorrect. There was no prior Ghurid possession of Kannauj through marriage politics.
- D. Incorrect. The Chahamanas were opponents on the frontier, not custodians of Ghazni for the Ghurids.

Trap: explaining the Ghurid turn to India by later institutions instead of twelfth-century strategic pressures.

Workbook MCQ 19

What was the chief analytical significance of Muizz al-Din's defeat in Gujarat in 1178?

- A. It ended all Ghurid interest in India permanently.
- B. It immediately transferred Delhi to the Ghurids.
- C. It demonstrated that the desert-Gujarat route could fail badly and encouraged a Punjab-first strategy instead.
- D. It proved Rajput states never lost a later battle.

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Muizz al-Din remained active in India and later achieved major successes through another route.
- B. Incorrect. Delhi became relevant only after the later Tarain-Chandawar sequence.
- C. Correct. The defeat redirected strategy toward Punjab, where firmer bases and lines of operation could be built.
- D. Incorrect. One Ghurid defeat in 1178 does not erase later reversals in 1192 and 1194.

Trap: reading Gujarat 1178 either as a final stoppage or as an irrelevant hiccup instead of a strategic lesson.

Workbook MCQ 20

Which sequence best represents the main Ghurid route to wider conquest in India?

- A. Chandawar -> Tarain II -> Gujarat victory -> capture of Multan
- B. Bengal raids -> Somnath -> Lahore -> Tarain I
- C. Tarain II -> Gujarat defeat -> Multan/Uchch -> Tarain I
- D. Multan/Uchch -> Gujarat defeat -> Lahore/Punjab base -> Tarain I -> Tarain II -> Chandawar

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. It begins with the late consequence and inserts a Gujarat victory that never occurred.
- B. Incorrect. Somnath belongs to Mahmud, not to Muizz al-Din's route of conquest.
- C. Incorrect. The order is reversed; Multan/Uchch and Gujarat came before the Tarain battles.
- D. Correct. This sequence tracks the eastward build-up from frontier footholds to the decisive Gangetic opening.

Trap: mixing Mahmud's and Muizz al-Din's campaigns into one false conquest sequence.

Workbook MCQ 21

What made Tabarhinda especially important in the run-up to Tarain?

- A. Its seizure threatened the Chahamana frontier and forced Prithviraj into a major response.
- B. It was the port from which Mahmud sailed to Somnath.
- C. It housed al-Biruni's Sanskrit school.
- D. It was Jaichandra's capital on the Ganga.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Tabarhinda mattered because it turned frontier pressure into a direct Chahamana military confrontation.
- B. Incorrect. Mahmud's Somnath route was not a sea voyage launched from Tabarhinda.
- C. Incorrect. The fort has strategic significance here, not a scholarly institutional role in al-Biruni's career.
- D. Incorrect. Jaichandra's sphere lay around Kannauj, not at Tabarhinda.

Trap: missing how a single fort seizure can trigger a major field battle in frontier politics.

Workbook MCQ 22

Which factor most clearly explains the reversal between 1191 and 1192 without resorting to inevitabilism?

- A. Prithviraj never fielded a serious force in 1191.
- B. The Ghurids returned after defeat with reorganised forces, tactical learning and better use of mounted harassment and reserves.
- C. Tarain II was won solely because gunpowder reached north India.
- D. Muizz al-Din was absent from the second campaign.

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. Tarain I itself proves that Prithviraj fielded a capable force able to defeat Muizz al-Din.
- B. Correct. The key is learning after defeat, not a myth of automatic superiority.
- C. Incorrect. Gunpowder is anachronistic for explaining Tarain II.
- D. Incorrect. Muizz al-Din led the return campaign rather than sitting it out.

Trap: turning Tarain II into a miracle weapon story instead of a study in adaptation after defeat.

Workbook MCQ 23

Which interpretation of Prithviraj's defeat is most defensible?

- A. The Sanyogita romance by itself explains the loss.
- B. Tarain II shows Rajput armies had no battlefield capacity whatsoever.
- C. Political rivalry, fragmented coordination and Ghurid adaptation matter more than later romantic legend.
- D. Jaichandra commanded the Chahamana cavalry wing at Tarain II.

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Romantic legend cannot replace analysis of coalition politics, campaign response and tactics.
- B. Incorrect. Tarain I demonstrates substantial Rajput battlefield capacity against the same opponent.
- C. Correct. This explanation keeps the focus on political-military structure rather than literary myth.
- D. Incorrect. Jaichandra was a rival ruler, not Prithviraj's field commander at Tarain II.

Trap: substituting later romance and folklore for the harder work of political explanation.

Workbook MCQ 24

What did Chandawar in 1194 do most directly?

- A. Restore Ghaznavid authority in Lahore.
- B. Create instant uniform control from Gujarat to Bihar.
- C. Replace every local elite in the doab overnight.
- D. Break Jaichandra's power and open the upper Ganga valley to deeper Ghurid advance and plunder.

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. Chandawar advanced Ghurid fortunes; it did not revive Ghaznavid authority.
- B. Incorrect. Even after Chandawar, conquest and consolidation remained uneven and staged.
- C. Incorrect. Major victories disrupted coordination centres but did not erase all local elites at once.
- D. Correct. The battle's immediate significance lay in crippling Jaichandra and widening access into the upper Ganga region.

Trap: mistaking a decisive regional battle for instant total administrative transformation.

Workbook MCQ 25

Which early post-Tarain policy is described most accurately?

- A. The Ghurids initially used vassalage and retained local rulers in places such as Delhi-Ajmer before rebellions pushed fuller occupation.
- B. They abolished every intermediary immediately after Tarain II and administered every village directly.
- C. They withdrew from Delhi to focus only on Khurasan.
- D. They declared Bakhtiyar Khalji king of Ajmer in 1192.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Early control often moved through subordinate arrangements before repeated rebellions demanded heavier occupation.
- B. Incorrect. Scarce manpower made instant direct administration of every locality unrealistic.
- C. Incorrect. Delhi-Ajmer became more central after Tarain rather than being abandoned.
- D. Incorrect. Bakhtiyar's eastern role had nothing to do with a coronation at Ajmer.

Trap: assuming conquest automatically produced fully centralised direct rule from the first month.

Workbook MCQ 26

Which set of places best fits the fort-and-route strategy associated with Aibak's Indian operations before 1206?

- A. Madurai, Kanchi and Tanjavur
- B. Hansi, Samana, Bayana and Gwalior
- C. Somnath, Dwarka and Cambay
- D. Waihind, Ghazni and Bukhara

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. Those southern centres lie outside the north Indian conquest corridor of Topic 02.
- B. Correct. These forts illustrate the north-western and doab-linked chain through which occupation was extended and secured.
- C. Incorrect. These Gujarat coastal sites do not represent Aibak's fort-grid in the post-Tarain phase.
- D. Incorrect. Waihind and Ghazni belong to the earlier frontier story, while Bukhara is outside this Indian fort sequence.

Trap: losing the geography of consolidation and thereby confusing raided sites with held forts.

Workbook MCQ 27

Which statement about Bakhtiyar Khalji's eastern thrust is most accurate?

- A. It instantly ended every Sena successor centre in Bengal.
- B. It was a naval campaign coordinated from Somnath.
- C. It damaged major monasteries in Bihar and displaced the Sena court from Nadia, but control remained uneven and contested.
- D. It belongs to Mahmud's eleventh-century phase.

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Sena power and regional resistance did not vanish in one blow everywhere.
- B. Incorrect. Bakhtiyar's eastern drive was a fast cavalry-led land campaign, not a naval operation from western India.
- C. Correct. The thrust was highly disruptive, yet it did not create uniform Bengal control overnight.
- D. Incorrect. Bakhtiyar belongs to the later Ghurid expansion, not to Mahmud's era.

Trap: mistaking a dramatic strike on courts and monasteries for immediate, homogeneous state formation across the east.

Workbook MCQ 28

What does the temporary inability to retain Anhilwara after a Ghurid force reached it best illustrate?

- A. That Gujarat had never been invaded from the north-west.
- B. That Muizz al-Din preferred naval expansion.
- C. That Rajput states always fought as a single coordinated union.
- D. That operational reach could exceed garrison capacity and long-term consolidation.

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. The issue was not impossibility of invasion but difficulty of holding what had been reached.
- B. Incorrect. The example concerns land campaigning and retention limits, not naval preference.
- C. Incorrect. Failure to hold a city does not prove a timeless pan-Rajput unified command.
- D. Correct. A force may win access or even capture, yet still lack the manpower and institutions for durable occupation.

Trap: confusing demonstrable military penetration with completed consolidation.

Workbook MCQ 29

A student says, "The Rajputs lost because Turks simply had better horses." Which correction is strongest?

- A. Horses mattered, but the larger issue was an interacting military system of mobility, command, reserves, finance, intelligence and frontier bases.
- B. The problem was only that Rajputs never used cavalry at all.
- C. Elephants always defeated mounted archers, so the premise is impossible.
- D. Weapons technology was identical, so no explanation is needed.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. A single-animal explanation misses the wider organisational system that converted mobility into victory.
- B. Incorrect. Rajput forces did use cavalry; the issue is comparative organisation, not total absence.
- C. Incorrect. Elephants could be important, but they did not automatically negate mobile archery and reserve tactics.
- D. Incorrect. The question demands a layered explanation, not a refusal to explain defeat at all.

Trap: reducing a system-level military comparison to one vivid but incomplete battlefield image.

Workbook MCQ 30

Which source judgement is incorrect?

- A. Chahamana inscriptions help reconstruct royal claims but remain eulogistic.
- B. Prithviraj Raso is a near-contemporary eyewitness battle report usable as literal chronology.
- C. Coins and inscriptions can corroborate titles, occupation and negotiated authority.
- D. Hasan Nizami reflects conquest politics through a courtly lens rather than neutral reportage.

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. This judgement is sound because inscriptions illuminate claims while still needing genre caution.
- B. Correct. Prithviraj Raso is a later layered epic tradition and cannot be treated as literal battlefield chronology.
- C. Incorrect. Material evidence often helps verify authority, titles and sequences that literary texts exaggerate.
- D. Incorrect. Hasan Nizami is indeed shaped by patronage and literary display rather than detached reporting.

Trap: elevating a famous heroic text into an eyewitness war diary simply because it is culturally influential.

Workbook MCQ 31

Which historiographical approach is most defensible for this topic?

- A. Use only court chronicles because inscriptions are silent on ideas.
- B. Reduce every campaign to communal hatred and dismiss revenue or logistics.
- C. Triangulate chronicles, inscriptions, coins, archaeology and later memory, while asking what each genre can and cannot prove.
- D. Treat later nationalist memory as sufficient evidence for eleventh-century operational detail.

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Court chronicles are essential but incomplete without material and non-court comparison.
- B. Incorrect. One-factor communal reduction erases strategic, fiscal and logistical evidence central to the topic.
- C. Correct. Triangulation respects the different evidentiary reach and limits of each archive.
- D. Incorrect. Later memory may matter for reception history, but it cannot substitute for contemporary operational evidence.

Trap: using one archive or one ideology to cancel the rest of the evidentiary field.

Workbook MCQ 32

Which conclusion best respects the topic boundary at 1206?

- A. The death of Muizz al-Din is irrelevant because Topic 02 continues through the whole Mamluk Sultanate.
- B. Aibak's independent reign after 1206 is the central subject of Topic 02.
- C. Iltutmish's consolidation should replace discussion of Tarain and Chandawar here.
- D. Topic 02 ends with the Ghurid conquest-phase opening; the independent Sultanate consolidation after 1206 belongs to Topic 03.

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. The topic intentionally stops before the full Mamluk-Sultanate consolidation story.
- B. Incorrect. Aibak's post-1206 independent reign belongs to the next topic, not the bounded invasion phase here.
- C. Incorrect. Tarain and Chandawar are core to Topic 02 and cannot be displaced by later Sultanate developments.
- D. Correct. This boundary keeps the workbook focused on invasion, conquest-opening and delegated expansion up to 1206.

Trap: bleeding Topic 03's Sultanate consolidation backward into a workbook that should stop at the conquest threshold.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Component	Count
Retained adjacent PYQs	3
Retained original 10-mark models	2
Retained original 15-mark models	2
Retained original 20-mark models	2

Adjacent PYQ 01 - 2022 Prelims GS-I Q96: Somnath Temple and al-Biruni

Status: adjacent - official wording is locally verifiable through the repository route under Indian Art and Culture Topic 13; the local repository does not preserve the official key, so the answer key here remains inferred from statement-wise verification.

Question: The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple at Veraval. Which of the following statements are correct regarding Somnath Temple? (1) Somnath Temple is one of the Jyotirlinga shrines. (2) A description of Somnath Temple was given by Al-Biruni. (3) Pran Pratishtha of Somnath Temple (installation of the present day temple) was done by President S. Radhakrishnan.

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A - 1 and 2 only (INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED; high confidence).

Model solution

- Statement 1 is correct: Somnath is one of the twelve Jyotirlinga shrines.
- Statement 2 is correct: al-Biruni's writing includes a description relevant to Somnath.
- Statement 3 is incorrect: the consecration of the reconstructed present temple in 1951 was performed by President Rajendra Prasad, not S. Radhakrishnan.
- TOPIC LINK: The question tests al-Biruni as a source and modern Somnath memory, not only temple chronology.
- LIMIT: The answer does not validate every later narrative about Mahmud's 1025 raid.

Why this earns marks: It tests each statement independently, gives the key-status warning, links the fact to source criticism and avoids importing contested raid details.

Demand decoding: Treat "The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple at..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple at...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Adjacent PYQ 02 - 2018 GS-I Mains: Chinese and Arab travellers

Status: adjacent - official wording is routed to Ancient History Sources Topic 02, but the question is retained here because al-Biruni is a core Arab-source anchor for Topic 02.

Question: Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the reconstruction of the history of India. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

- Direct thesis: Chinese and Arab accounts are indispensable external witnesses when their itinerary, genre, language and audience are tested against Indian texts, inscriptions, coins and archaeology.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Xuanzang's seventh-century pilgrimage record describes Harsha's political world, Nalanda and Buddhist geography. It reconstructs institutions and routes, but a Buddhist pilgrim naturally magnified monasteries and sacred centres.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Sulaiman and al-Masudi noticed major Indian powers, ports and commerce connected with the Persian Gulf. They prove India's wide political and trading reputation, though some information circulated through merchants rather than direct observation.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Al-Biruni's Kitab al-Hind used Sanskrit learning to compare religion, astronomy, calendars and social classification. Its analytical precision is exceptional, yet Brahmanical textual

access and a north-western setting narrow its social reach.

- Conclusion: These travellers are therefore high-value comparative and corroborative sources, not neutral photographs of all-India conditions.

Why this earns marks: It fulfils 'assess', compares three named source clusters, explains what each reconstructs, supplies a limitation for each and ends with a graded corroboration-based judgement.

Demand decoding: The question asks you to weigh, not merely list, the Chinese and Arab travellers named in the syllabus tradition - Xuanzang, Sulaiman/al-Masudi and al-Biruni - against India's own textual, inscriptional and archaeological record, so the answer must show what each traveller adds and where each is compromised by genre or vantage point.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with a two-line thesis on comparative corroboration; take Xuanzang, the Arab geographers and al-Biruni in turn as claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit; close by naming the two or three domains (polity, trade, religion/science) where these outsiders reconstruct history that Indian sources alone would leave thinner.

How to improve this answer: Add one more traveller or text this answer omits - for example Fa-Hien for an earlier baseline or Marco Polo/Ibn Battuta for a later comparison - and state precisely which additional fact only that source supplies, to push the answer from three evidence units toward the full available range.

Adjacent PYQ 03 - 2020 GS-I Mains: Persian literary sources

Status: adjacent - official wording is routed to Medieval History Topic 24, but the question is retained here because Ghaznavid and Ghurid Persian chronicles are indispensable to Topic 02's source base.

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

- Direct thesis: Persian works reflect medieval political ideals, conquest, administration, dissent and social worlds, but their 'spirit of the age' becomes representative only through comparison across genres and non-court evidence.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: al-Utbi's ornate Kitab al-Yamini celebrates Sabuktigin and Mahmud and reveals Ghaznavid legitimacy, ghazi language and court ambition. Panegyric, weak Indian geography and its pre-Somnath end limit literal use.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Hasan Nizami's Taj al-Ma'asir and Minhaj-us-Siraj's Tabaqat-i Nasiri record conquest, vassalage, Ghurid genealogy and early Sultanate succession. Court patronage, chronological distance and elite focus shape their selection.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Barani's Tarikh-i Firoz Shahi and normative Fatawa-i Jahandari expose Sultanate politics and aristocratic-orthodox ideals. His didactic hierarchy cannot represent all society.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Abul Fazl's Akbarnama and Ain-i Akbari display Mughal sovereignty and bureaucratic classification, while Badauni preserves conservative dissent. Both are court-centred and partisan in different directions.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Amir Khusrau's panegyric and the Sufi conversations of Fawa'id-ul-Fu'ad widen the archive toward literary encounter and khanqah life, yet remain mediated compositions.
- Conclusion: Persian literature reflects several competing 'spirits' - royal, clerical, administrative, poetic and devotional - rather than one transparent age.

Why this earns marks: It comments rather than lists, spans early Ghaznavid/Ghurid to Sultanate/Mughal genres, links six named evidence clusters to social reach and patronage limits, and gives a qualified verdict.

Demand decoding: 'Comment' here means take a position on whether 'spirit of the age' is a safe generalisation, then test it against the five named genre-clusters (Ghaznavid panegyric, Ghurid-Delhi chronicle, Sultanate normative history, Mughal court/dissent writing, Sufi-poetic literature) rather than restating the prompt.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: State the thesis that 'spirit of the age' is plural, not singular; move chronologically through al-Utbi, Hasan Nizami/Minhaj, Barani, Abul Fazl/Badauni and Amir Khusrau/Sufi conversations as five claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit units; close by naming the patronage bias that runs through all five.

How to improve this answer: Strengthen the weakest unit - Amir Khusrau/Sufi conversations - with one more concrete text (for example Barani's own admission of bias, or a specific Khusrau masnavi) and state exactly which social group's 'spirit' that addition still leaves unrecovered.

PYQ search conclusion

- No narrowly battle-specific GS Mains PYQ was located in the bounded repository paper/routing set.
- Topic 02 therefore retains three adjacent applications rather than any exact-topic routed GS Mains PYQ.

Mains 10M-1 - Mahmud's motives

Status: inferred - this is an original in-package model on Mahmud's motives; no official UPSC key exists for a question of this exact wording.

Question: Mahmud of Ghazni's Indian campaigns cannot be explained by religious zeal alone. Explain. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Religious rhetoric was politically important, but Mahmud's campaigns joined it to frontier security, dynastic legitimacy, revenue extraction and the financing of Central Asian wars.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: al-Utbi's panegyric and Mahmud's image as ghazi/but-shikan legitimised victory and mobilised followers. Court rhetoric, however, cannot reveal the whole strategic calculus.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: The long wars against Jayapala and Anandapala and the annexation of Punjab/Multan secured Ghazni's south-eastern frontier. This territorial aim differs from the non-annexing Mathura-Kanauj and Somnath raids.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Wealth from 1018 and 1025 supported reward networks, Ghazni's display and wars in Khurasan. Loot estimates are rhetorical, but the selection of rich political-temple centres is clear.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Hindu officers and Jat soldiers served Ghaznavid armies. This does not erase religious violence; it disproves a simple civilisational bloc model.
- Conclusion: Religion supplied a powerful idiom, while state security, resources and transregional competition structured Mahmud's repeated choices.

Why this earns marks: It preserves religious agency without monocausality, contrasts territorial and raiding objectives and uses four named evidence units in a concise structure.

Demand decoding: 'Explain' requires you to concede the religious-zeal claim only partially, then build a ranked multi-causal account - this question fails any answer that either denies religious rhetoric outright or treats it as the sole driver.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Thesis first: religion supplied idiom, not the whole calculus; take al-Utbi's ghazi framing, the Punjab/Multan territorial aim versus the non-annexing raids, the 1018/1025 wealth flows, and Hindu-Jat service together as four claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit units; close by ranking security and revenue above rhetoric for the pattern as a whole.

How to improve this answer: Add the Central Asian wars/Khurasan-Transoxiana dimension as a fifth explicit unit - this answer names it in the thesis but never evidences it - citing one specific rival (for example the Qarakhanids) whose pressure Mahmud's Indian wealth helped him counter.

Mains 10M-2 - Tarain comparison

Status: inferred - this is an original in-package model on the Tarain reversal; no official UPSC key exists for a question of this exact wording.

Question: What explains the reversal between the First and Second Battles of Tarain? (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The reversal came from Ghurid learning, preparation and integrated manoeuvre, combined with the Chahamana failure to convert the 1191 victory into frontier recovery; it was not predetermined military superiority.

- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Prithviraj's immediate response to Tabarhinda produced a complete victory in 1191. This proves Rajput battlefield capacity, though the subsequent siege did not expel the Ghurids from Punjab.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Muizz al-Din returned after reorganising disgraced commanders and preparing a renewed army. The narrative of exact numbers is exaggerated, but institutional learning is visible.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Satish Chandra describes mounted archers harassing slower formations from several directions in 1192. Mobility and reserves mattered, though the account is not a modern battlefield survey.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Prithviraj's feudatory coalition had large resources but more fragmented command. Later Sanyogita romance cannot substitute for political analysis.
- Conclusion: Tarain II was a contingent victory created by adaptation, command and strategy after a real Ghurid defeat.

Why this earns marks: It directly compares both battles, uses 1191 as counter-evidence, explains mechanisms and rejects numbers, betrayal and weapon monocausality.

Demand decoding: The question wants a mechanism-level explanation of the reversal, not a battle narrative - you must show what changed between 1191 and 1192 on both sides, using Tarain I itself as the compulsory counter-evidence against inevitability.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Thesis: contingent reversal, not innate superiority; sequence Prithviraj's 1191 victory and its incomplete follow-through, Muizz al-Din's reorganisation, the mounted-archery/reserve tactics of 1192, and Chahamana coalition fragmentation as four claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit units; close by naming command integration as the deciding variable.

How to improve this answer: This answer under-uses the political-aftermath dimension - add one line on what happened to Prithviraj's polity immediately after 1192 (capture/execution traditions and their source problems) to complete the causal chain beyond the battlefield.

Mains 15M-1 - Somnath source criticism and memory

Status: inferred - this is an original in-package model on Somnath source criticism and memory; no official UPSC key exists for a question of this exact wording.

Question: Discuss the Somnath raid through source criticism and explain why its later memory cannot be treated as a simple mirror of 1025. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The 1025 Somnath raid was a major act of plunder, iconoclasm and royal display, but its reconstruction requires separating early reports, later Persian amplification, local records, material phases and modern political memory.
- Event and motive: Somnath joined temple wealth, pilgrimage, port-region commerce and royal symbolism. Mahmud's return without annexing Gujarat supports a high-prestige raid rather than a durable provincial project. This does not reduce the violence to economics alone because ghazi and image-breaking rhetoric carried political-religious value.
- Source chronology: al-Utbi is crucial for Mahmud's earlier ideology but his chronicle ends before Somnath. al-Biruni supplies an early learned description, while later Persian histories often elaborate victory and destruction. Chronological distance and panegyric borrowing require corroboration.
- Local and material evidence: Sanskrit, Jain and epigraphic traditions illuminate rebuilding, patronage and different memory priorities. Their silence or brevity cannot prove indifference, because donation and genealogy records were not trauma chronicles and survive selectively.
- Later memory: Colonial retrieval, nationalist reconstruction and communal politics transformed Somnath into a symbol of civilisational humiliation or recovery. Romila Thapar's multi-voice approach shows that event and retrospective meaning belong to distinct analytical layers.
- Qualification: Exact defender numbers, loot totals, speeches and dramatic image-ransom stories should be excluded unless securely corroborated.

- Conclusion: Somnath is historically important precisely because it combines a recoverable raid with changing political memories; source criticism protects both facts and complexity.

Why this earns marks: It answers both event and memory, ranks five evidence layers, names al-Utbi/al-Biruni/Thapar, states non-annexation and excludes embellished detail.

Demand decoding: 'Discuss' plus the explicit two-part question (source criticism AND why memory is not a mirror) means you must budget marks across both halves - an answer that only narrates the 1025 raid without a memory-politics section will lose half its marks.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Thesis: event and memory are separable analytical layers; work through event/motive, source chronology (al-Utbi's silence, al-Biruni, later Persian elaboration), local/material evidence, and the colonial-nationalist-communal memory sequence as five claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit units; close by naming Romila Thapar's multi-voice reading as the synthesising move.

How to improve this answer: The material-evidence unit is the thinnest - add one named site/inscription/temple-phase detail (rather than a general reference to 'epigraphic traditions') to make the evidentiary layer as concrete as the textual one.

Mains 15M-2 - Conquest versus consolidation

Status: inferred - this is an original in-package model on conquest versus consolidation; no official UPSC key exists for a question of this exact wording.

Question: Distinguish conquest from consolidation in the Ghurid expansion, with special reference to Aibak and the eastern campaigns. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Tarain and Chandawar broke major regional coordinating centres, but durable rule required delegated occupation, forts, tribute, local accommodation and repeated suppression; conquest therefore preceded rather than completed consolidation.
- Battlefield opening: Tarain II opened Delhi-Ajmer and Chandawar disrupted Gahadavala power. Their significance was strategic, but neither battle supplied administrators, revenue information or secure countryside control.
- Aibak's mechanism: Muizz al-Din left Qutb al-Din Aibak to occupy Delhi, manage Ajmer rebellions and extend into the doab. Hansi, Samana, Bayana and Gwalior illustrate a fort-and-route strategy. A fort, however, did not guarantee surrounding agrarian obedience.
- Accommodation: Hasan Nizami and coin evidence cited by Satish Chandra suggest initial subordinate arrangements with Tomar/Chahamana authority. Such vassalage economised scarce manpower; rebellion could produce direct occupation. Coin reading and sequence remain debated.
- Distance limit: A Ghurid force took Anhilwara but could not retain it. This proves operational reach exceeded garrison capacity.
- Eastern bound: Bakhtiyar Khalji's Bihar raids and Nadia-Lakhnauti thrust demonstrate surprise and delegated initiative. They damaged major monasteries and displaced the Sena court from Nadia, but Sena successors and regional resistance continued; one attack did not create uniform Bengal rule or single-handedly end Buddhism.
- Conclusion: Consolidation was a negotiated, violent and decades-long process completed only partly under the Ghurids and carried forward by the Delhi Sultanate.

Why this earns marks: It defines both concepts, uses Aibak, forts, vassalage, Anhilwara and Bakhtiyar as evidence, and maintains the Bihar-Bengal source caution.

Demand decoding: 'Distinguish' demands two clearly separated definitions before any narrative - conquest as battlefield defeat of a coordinating power, consolidation as the administrative-military mechanism that follows - with Aibak and the eastern campaigns used as the compulsory worked examples, not optional colour.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Define both terms in the thesis; move through the battlefield opening (Tarain II/Chandawar), Aibak's fort-and-route mechanism, accommodation/vassalage evidence, the Anhilwara distance limit, and Bakhtiyar's bounded eastern thrust as five claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit units; close by naming the Delhi Sultanate, not the Ghurids, as consolidation's real completion.

How to improve this answer: The accommodation unit hedges with 'coin reading and sequence remain debated' - replace the hedge with one named numismatic or textual detail (a specific coin type or a Hasan Nizami passage) so the qualification reads as informed caution rather than an unfilled gap.

Mains 20M-1 - Why Ghurid rule became wider and more durable

Status: inferred - this is an original in-package model comparing Ghaznavid and Ghurid durability; no official UPSC key exists for a question of this exact wording.

Question: Why did the Ghurids establish wider and more durable rule in the Gangetic plain than the Ghaznavids? Analyse. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The contrast arose from different strategic objectives, inherited bases, timing, delegation and institutional aftermath. It cannot be reduced to the personal ability of Mahmud and Muizz al-Din or to a timeless military superiority.
- Different objectives: Mahmud combined frontier security and Punjab annexation with repeated deep raids whose revenue, prestige and religious legitimation served a Central Asian empire. Mathura-Kanauj in 1018 and Somnath in 1025 produced reach without Gangetic administration. Muizz al-Din, by contrast, repeatedly sought tribute, forts and territorial succession after Punjab.
- Base and route: Mahmud's defeat of the Shahis and control of Punjab breached the frontier. The Ghurids inherited this achievement, removed Khusrau Malik from Lahore in 1186 and later made Delhi an inland operational base. This shortened lines to the doab.
- Learning and timing: Muizz al-Din lost in Gujarat in 1178 and at Tarain in 1191, then shifted route and preparation. The late-twelfth-century rivalry among Chauhans and Gahadavalas created opportunities, but Tarain I proves the outcome was not inevitable.
- Delegation: Aibak continuously managed Delhi, Ajmer, forts and doab expansion while Muizz al-Din returned west. Bakhtiyar and other commanders extended initiative eastward. This commander network converted royal campaigns into repeated occupation.
- Political mechanisms: Vassal arrangements, tribute, garrisons and use of existing revenue channels economised manpower. The failure to hold Anhilwara and long resistance show their limits.
- Institutional succession: After 1206, the Ghurid empire fragmented, but Aibak and Iltutmish built an Indian-centred Sultanate. No comparable Ghaznavid Gangetic successor had followed Mahmud.
- Qualification: Mahmud was often the more consistently successful general, while Ghurid consolidation remained uneven and took decades.
- Conclusion: Ghaznavid Punjab was the strategic foundation; Ghurid objectives, delegation and post-conquest institutions converted that foundation into a more durable north Indian state.

Why this earns marks: It ranks causes across objective, base, timing, learning, delegation and succession, compares precise campaigns and ends with a graded rather than triumphalist verdict.

Demand decoding: 'Analyse' at 20 marks requires a genuinely comparative structure across both dynasties on every axis (objective, base, timing, delegation, succession) - a chronological retelling of Ghurid campaigns without matching each point back to the Ghaznavids will read as description, not analysis.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Thesis names five comparative axes; take objectives, base/route, learning/timing, delegation and institutional succession as five paired claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit units, each naming both the Ghaznavid and Ghurid side; close with the qualification that Mahmud was often the abler general even though his dynasty produced the less durable outcome.

How to improve this answer: The 'political mechanisms' unit is the most generic of the six - replace 'vassal arrangements, tribute, garrisons' with one named instance already available elsewhere in this package (Aibak's Bayana-Gwalior garrisons) to keep every unit at the same evidentiary density.

Mains 20M-2 - Sources and historiography

Status: inferred - this is an original in-package model on sources and historiography; no official UPSC key exists for a question of this exact wording.

Question: Evaluate the sources and historiographical approaches used to reconstruct the Ghaznavid and Ghurid invasions of India. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Reconstruction depends on court chronicles, comparative scholarship, Indic literary-epigraphic traditions and material evidence, each illuminating a different layer and each requiring scrutiny of date, genre, patronage and silence.
- Ghaznavid chronicles: al-Utbi's Kitab al-Yamini offers early campaign and legitimacy language but is ornate panegyric with weak Indian geography and ends before Somnath. Gardizi is more concise but court-linked and derivative in places. Bayhaqi gives unusually rich chancery and fiscal politics, chiefly for Masud's era and through a fragmentary elite archive.
- Al-Biruni: Kitab al-Hind contributes Sanskrit-based comparison in religion, astronomy and society. Its analytical independence is exceptional, yet learned Brahmanical interlocutors and north-western location narrow social reach.
- Ghurid-Delhi sources: Hasan Nizami provides an early conquest narrative shaped by Aibak's court and literary display. Minhaj's Tabaqat-i Nasiri preserves Ghurid genealogy and early Sultanate sequence but was completed c. 1260 under Delhi patronage. Modern UPenn work shows the value of reading it against the grain for Ghur's local society.
- Indic sources: Prithviraja Vijaya and Chahamana inscriptions provide royal self-representation; Prithviraj Raso and later epics reveal memory rather than eyewitness fact. Silence cannot be made proof of no event.
- Material archive: coins linked to negotiated authority, Ghazni and Jam monuments, Qutb inscriptions and fort landscapes can corroborate titles, patronage and occupation. Attribution, reuse, survival and circulation limits remain.
- Historiography: Colonial writing civilisationalised dynastic rupture; nationalist work recovered agency but could romanticise heroes; communal readings absolutised religion; materialist and military studies restored revenue, organisation and logistics; Persianate and memory studies highlight connection and archive construction.
- Conclusion: The strongest account triangulates sources and retains both violence and contingency. It neither repeats court victory rhetoric nor dissolves events into scepticism.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates seven named source clusters and five historiographical approaches, states what each proves and limits, and concludes with a defensible method.

Demand decoding: 'Evaluate' requires a judgement on the relative reliability and reach of each source class, not just a list - the answer must end by ranking which combination of sources is least distorted, which this question is specifically testing.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Thesis on layered, mutually correcting evidence; take Ghaznavid chronicles, al-Biruni, Ghurid-Delhi chronicles, Indic textual/epigraphic sources and material evidence as five claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit units; close by ranking material/epigraphic evidence as the most independent check on all four textual traditions.

How to improve this answer: The historiography paragraph names five schools in one sentence without evidence for each - pick the two most exam-relevant (colonial and materialist) and give one named historian or argument for each, rather than a single unsupported list.